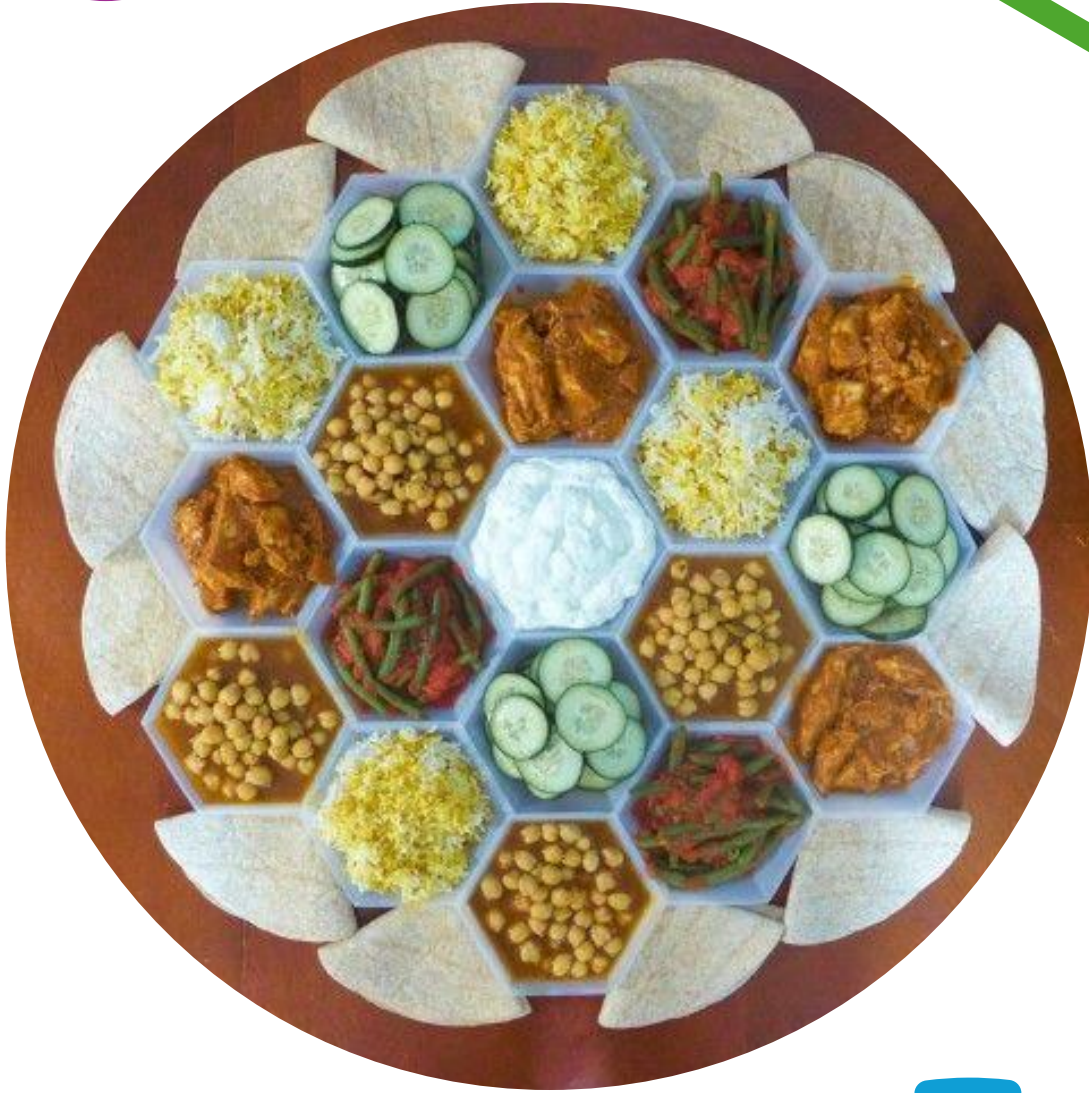


A Discussion on Gastronomy by Reflecting on “A Settler’s Cookbook”

Sumaiya Tasnim

ENG 110: Literature for Life



History untold and blurred: Who are the Asian African Muslims and Hindus residing in Uganda?

- <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=CZEvHUns9oM>
- <https://youtu.be/p-i0JVip9N4?si=h4lirVNssnCjc5jt>
- <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=y7ogJeB8z3M>
- Idi Amin's expulsion in 1972
- Memoir on belonging; Sense of loss; Memory

The Wahindi-Asian Settlers:

- Asian Settlers (Indian civilians from Gujarat and Punjab) were brought to East Africa (between 1806-1901) to build a railway track that enabled Britain to extend its colony from **Mombasa to Kampala's** seven hills
 - They aided in creating small local businesses and shops, ultimately colonizing the interior parts of East Africa.
 - Shortly after the independence of East Africa from British imperialism and colonial practice (December 1963), the African Asian communities were given the option to stay back in Africa or move to Britain via citizenship. Both countries **denied citizenship** to the Asian African communities.
-

...

- The crisis came in Idi Amin's Uganda in 1972, but as Yasmin Alibhai-Brown suggests, it could have happened anywhere in East Africa.
- Islam facilitated trade with foreign merchants, mostly Muslims. Many testimonies show that the position of middlemen occupied by Swahili limited direct contact between suppliers of goods.
- The term “African” therefore primarily referred to people unfamiliar with the urban trade life at the coast, living in the towns and villages of the hinterland. In the case of migrants from the Indian subcontinent, integration into Swahili society depended upon the type of migration.



■ ■ ■

- From seasonal mobile foreigners unfamiliar with the Swahili culture, Indian merchants progressively became “internal aliens” in a society structured by old hierarchies that left them little room and weighed heavily on the relationship they could build with the local population.
- Swahili society was structured based on the practice of Islam and the adoption of the Middle East Arab culture rather than with reference to skin colour and geographical origin (Caplan and Le Guennec 1991).

■ ■ ■ ■

“I remember ululations rising up, the calls of a gathering crowd as a thief was spotted grabbing a handbag or, more commonly, fruit or bread from some vendor. Sometimes the person was innocent, just an unfortunate who met a surge of violent action.”

“Particular foods remind me of individuals.”

“...off to their graves, their favorite dishes were brought to the mosque by relatives. After prayers, the sacred victuals were bought for a nominal sum by the poor, lonely, ill, and hard-pressed whose pleasure upon eating would be transported to the tongues of the departed as they entered the forgiving gates of paradise, so we believed.”

■ ■ ■

“Implacable racial and class divisions between indigenous Africans and settler Asians were a fact of East African life and had been encouraged and institutionalized by the British. Asians had come to believe that their lighter skin and middle-class status made them superior to blacks, who now had power in their unforgiving hands.”

“In 1968 a tight quota was set to limit the entry into the UK of East African British Asians. The law was cruelly specific. Only those with indigenous British ancestry had the right to enter freely.”

■ ■ ■

“Wise philosopher-housewives calm the most distressed ladies, tell them they are going to a much better place with polite soldiers and definitely the thickest, most nutritious, unadulterated milk in the world. They exchange recipes for milky sweets and drinks, bicker over whose methods are the best. Time and sorrow pass as they get engrossed in this game. Gujarati, Punjabi, English, Hindi bounce from seat to seat. In East Africa, religion gave each community its own heaven and earth without causing any serious rifts. Hindu, Muslim, Sikh and Christian Asians had to bind together, to survive as visible minorities whose skin never turned native under the stupendous African sun.”

-
- “Food is intrinsically connected to economics, politics, communication, knowledge, marriage, trade and the movements of peoples.” (p.23)
 - “Our food bears testimony to this dynamic existence – creative, sometimes impertinent and playful blends of Indian, Pakistani, Arab, African, Chinese, and English, now Italian and American too, forever in flux.”

Analysis of “Enticing Blightie” (1972)

- Blightie: an informal term for Britain
- *Chili Bhajia, Tamarind and Date Dip, Coccothende, Hot Nuts, Perfect Boiled Rice*
- Sense of loss and identity/Reclaiming memory and identity through food
- Colonial History and Migration to Britain
- Potential Refugee History and Experiences with Racial Profiling
- Large parts of East Africa have been influenced by many different cultures, resulting in a melting pot of ingredients, flavors, and cooking techniques. Dishes are almost always cooked with a vast array of spices, which must be top quality to ensure a strong, pure flavor. Using black pepper ground from whole peppercorns or cinnamon that has been matured for up to twenty years, for example, is key to ensuring East African dishes have the required intensity.

■ ■ ■ ■

- The colonizers needed to displace labour invested for local needs while expanding and consolidating labour to meet the needs of the colonizers. By emphasizing a cash economy, farmers were forced to neglect their own needs, derided as subsistence farmers, and were made to offer their labour in exchange for wages. The colonial powers scored double on this count by introducing plantation agriculture and bringing in the locals as farm hands.
- Colonial agriculture thrived not only by producing crops for export, but it also benefited from altering the appetites of the colonized. These changes did not happen only through advertisements, the indigenous foods were denigrated as uncivilized and sometimes simply forgotten due to a chronic absence of the crops or ingredients for preparing the foods. Today, the erosion of varieties is exacerbated by many related factors including the prevalence of junk foods, hybridization of crop varieties, genetic manipulations, and hostile seed laws.

...

- Like black Americans seeking a past in old slave ports and white Americans who come seeking Scottish and Irish ancestries, we yearn to belong to the ancient civilizations of the Ganges and Indus.
- a rooted Sikh, say, with a green plot of land in the Punjab handed down over generations, or a proper Karachi expatriate like so many of my friends who can always return there when the going gets impossibly tough here. Many other East African Asians and their children feel the same emptiness, historically and geographically disconnected.

Gastronomy & Literature

- Adapt to the culinary practices of others while creating a communal livelihood between communities
- Keeping certain recipes alive and facilitating collective remembrance
- Food as a marker of violence, displacement, abuse, and diasporic representation
- Food as a representation of freed
- Food as a feminist marker

--

For happiness and despair, to relieve pain or to brighten the spirits, more an unwitting agent of support than mere solace, food fills the emotional void and heals the tragedy of exile and abandonment. It may function as a weapon and a shield, an insult and a way to atone, for reconciliation and making amends, for erotic appeal and Muslim charity. Its taste, smell and feel excite or numb the senses. (Tomczak as cited in Steiner 434)



Princess Sadruddin Aga Khan with Asian Ugandan refugees at a camp in Italy. Laila Datoo (5th from left, in a pink dress). was given the honours to accompany the Prince and Princess during their visit to the camp. Photo: Laila Datoo collection.

- If we approach food with curiosity, there is so much potential for cultural exchange and learning– which is one of the many reasons why I love to eat!”-Shirley Ting from Asian Canadian and Asian Migration Studies
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=tgJUInZ-7-4&ab_channel=BanijayDocumentaries